TOPIC 2 · PERSONALISATION, .RULES AND SKILLS FOR EXCEL
LAB 7 THEME · POWERPOINT DESIGN SKILL

Lab 7 — Create a PowerPoint Design Skill: From Plain to Professional

Maps to	LO2: create and improve a reusable maintenance skill in Excel and PowerPoint
Duration	30 minutes
Tools	Microsoft 365 Copilot · PowerPoint · Microsoft 365 Copilot web
Mock data	data/Northstar_Plain_Update.pptx
Course	GenAI for Engineers · v2.4
Prompts	https://tertiarycourses.github.io/IES-GenAI-for-Engineers/prompts/#lab-7

Goal

Northstar_Professional_Update.pptx, redesigned by your own northstar-deck-design skill.

What You Will Do

Turn a plain, unbranded PowerPoint deck into a professional Northstar deck by creating a design skill once and calling it with @.

What You Will Build

Northstar_Professional_Update.pptx, redesigned by your own northstar-deck-design skill.

Prerequisites

- Microsoft 365 account with Copilot available in Word, Excel, PowerPoint and Outlook. Availability depends on the assigned licence and tenant settings; confirm access with the trainer before class.
- Desktop Excel on Windows or Mac. Download this lab folder and open the files straight from its data folder; save any new file in the same folder. All data is fictional.

Data note

Northstar Water Services is a fictional water-pipe maintenance and service company. All service hubs, staff and work orders are synthetic. Use the fixed reporting date 2026-09-30; missing facts remain UNKNOWN. Proposals do not change real assignments. Training email drafts are never sent.

Steps

Step 1. Look at the plain deck. Open data/Northstar_Plain_Update.pptx in PowerPoint and save it as Northstar_Professional_Update.pptx. The numbers are right, but the slides are plain: black text, no header, no branding.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
Slides : 6
Look : plain black text, no colours, no header, no footer
```

Step 2. Write the skill. Go to https://copilot.cloud.microsoft, start a new chat, paste the prompt and send it. Read the reply: it starts with --- and the name northstar-deck-design. Copy the whole reply.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
MICROSOFT 365 COPILOT WEB:
Write a complete SKILL.md for a Copilot in PowerPoint skill named northstar-deck-design. Start with --- front matter: name: northstar-deck-design and description: Use when I ask to make a presentation look professional or apply the Northstar brand. Then write numbered steps: 1) Keep every slide, number and fact; change only the design. 2) Fonts: Segoe UI Semibold for titles, Segoe UI for body text. 3) Colours: navy #1F4E79, blue #2E75B6, teal #2A9D8F, light grey #F2F4F7 cards, white background. 4) Slide 1: navy background, large white title, teal subtitle. 5) Every other slide: a navy header bar with a white title and a thin teal line under it. 6) Turn key numbers into KPI cards with a big bold number and a short label. 7) At most 4 short bullets per slide, with plenty of white space. 8) A footer on every slide except slide 1: Northstar Water Services | 30 September 2026, and the slide number. 9) Check every slide and list anything you could not fix. Return only the SKILL.md text, starting with ---, without code fences.
```

Step 3. Add the skill to PowerPoint. In PowerPoint open Copilot and select + > Choose skills > Manage skills > Add skill. Paste the reply into the form and select Add. Short of time? Open data/templates/northstar-deck-design/SKILL.md in Notepad or TextEdit, copy all of it and paste that instead.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
Check : northstar-deck-design appears when you type @nor
```

Step 4. Transform the deck. Send the prompt and watch every slide change: a navy title slide, a header bar on each slide, KPI cards for the numbers and a footer.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
POWERPOINT COPILOT:
@northstar-deck-design Redesign this whole deck in the Northstar style. Keep every slide and every number.
```

Step 5. Check the result. Send the prompt and fix anything it lists. The numbers must not change: 120 total, 60 backlog, 50 overdue and 6 unassigned, cost S$35,827.50. Save the deck.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
POWERPOINT COPILOT:
@northstar-deck-design Check every slide against the skill. List any slide missing the header bar, footer, Northstar fonts or colours, and fix it. Do not change any number.
```

Copy buttons for every prompt: https://tertiarycourses.github.io/IES-GenAI-for-Engineers/prompts/#lab-7

Test It

Check	Expected result
Skill	northstar-deck-design added in PowerPoint and called with @.
Design	Navy title slide; header bar, KPI cards and footer on the other slides; Segoe UI fonts.
Facts unchanged	6 slides; 120 total, 60 backlog, 50 overdue and 6 unassigned; S$35,827.50.

Troubleshooting

If this happens	Fix
Copilot cannot see my file	In Excel, save the file and open Copilot again. In Word, PowerPoint or Outlook, upload the file with + > Upload images and files, and upload it again after you change it.
A number is different from the lab	Clear any slicers or filters, check the table has no extra rows, then ask again in a new chat.
A button or feature is missing	Check you are signed in with your course account and Microsoft 365 is up to date, then tell your trainer.

Challenge

Add a reference file such as brand-colours.md to the skill folder in OneDrive, mention it in SKILL.md, and apply the skill to a plain deck of your own.

Reflection

Which evidence proves the output is correct, and which decision still needs a person?